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USC Football Early Preseason Ranking Summary

This article discusses Bill Connelly's early SP+ preseason ranking for USC football heading into the 2026 season, highlighting their position within the Big Ten and the broader national landscape.

Key Events

- * **Bill Connelly's Early SP+ Ranking Release:** ESPN's Bill Connelly released his initial SP+ preseason rankings for the 2026 college football season.

- * **USC's Ranking Announcement:** USC was ranked No. 16 nationally in Connelly's early SP+ projections.

- * **Big Ten Conference Integration:** The article frames USC's ranking within the context of their new Big Ten conference affiliation.

Main Trends

- * **Anticipation for 2026 Season:** There's an early look and projection for the 2026 college football season, indicating a forward-looking trend in sports analysis.

- * **Data-Driven Preseason Projections:** The reliance on metrics like SP+ for early rankings demonstrates a trend towards analytical, objective assessments over subjective opinions.

- * **Big Ten Dominance/Strength:** The Big Ten is consistently presented as a strong conference, with multiple teams ranked highly, suggesting a trend of conference power concentration.

- * **USC's Continued Rebuilding/Development:** While ranked, USC is positioned as a team still working towards the top tier, indicating an ongoing development phase rather than a peak.

Important Facts

- * **USC's National Rank (SP+):** No. 16 nationally.

- * **USC's Big Ten Rank (SP+):** No. 5 in the Big Ten.

- * **Top Big Ten Teams (SP+):**

- * Ohio State: No. 2

- * Michigan: No. 3

- * Penn State: No. 6

- * Oregon: No. 10

- * **Author of Rankings:** Bill Connelly (ESPN).

- * **Ranking System:** SP+ (a widely respected analytical model).

- * **Season Covered:** 2026 college football season.